

MD-0007: Deidentification Semantics in SPEC §8.2

Field	Value
ID	MD-0007
Type	MD, Maintainer Decision
Status	Accepted
Normative?	No. Records the semantics the Steering Committee reads into an existing §8.2 field and authorizes a corrective specification edit; the edit itself, not this decision, carries any specification change.
Visibility	Public (standard governance)
Proposed date	2026-07-27
Accepted date	2026-07-31
Deciders	Steering Committee / maintainers (Princeton Medical Systems)
Related	GOVERNANCE.md §1; SPEC.md §8.2 (Imaging Sidecar JSON, containing the DeIdentification block); MD-0001; MD-0005; MD-0006; CONTRIBUTING.md

Affected published records

Item	Value
Concept DOI	10.5281/zenodo.19582716
Affected version	1.0.0, 10.5281/zenodo.19582717
Correction method	New version published under the concept DOI
Archived v1.0.0	Never modified

Decision

- 1. Upstream de-identification and downstream format conversion are distinct acts.** They are performed by different parties at different times for different purposes, and VIDS records them in different fields.
- 2. `Deidentification.Tool` names the tool of the de-identification act only.** The field denotes the act of de-identifying. It may name only the tool that performed that act.
- 3. Incidental metadata loss resulting from format conversion does not, by itself, constitute a documented de-identification act or make the conversion utility the de-identification tool.** A converter that drops header fields

as a side effect of writing a different container may reduce identifiability, but it has not performed the act §8.2 records. Naming it in `DeIdentification.Tool` misstates what was done to the data.

- 4. **Source-provided de-identification provenance stays attributed to the source.** Where the de-identification was performed upstream, the recorded tool, method and date are the source's, recorded faithfully at whatever granularity the source provides.
- 5. **A local conversion date must not be recorded as an upstream de-identification date.** Where the de-identification date is not available from the source, the field carries an approved recording-state sentinel, not a substitute value.

Rationale

MD-0006 establishes the general assertion-discipline rule. This decision applies that rule to the semantics of `DeIdentification.Tool` in SPEC §8.2.

§8.2 is an escalate-only section, so this decision memo precedes any edit to it.

The defect is in the specification, not in adopter practice. SPEC.md:473 gives the `DeIdentification.Tool` candidate list as "dcm2niix | CTP | pydicom | manual", placing a format converter beside CTP, which is a de-identification tool. EXAMPLES.md:115 and QUICKSTART.md:154 carry the same pairing as copyable worked examples, joining Method: HIPAA Safe Harbor to Tool: dcm2niix. An adopter who reads the specification, copies the example and populates the field as shown produces a record asserting that a format converter applied Safe Harbor. The pipeline author who did exactly this followed the specification correctly.

The distinction matters because `DeIdentification` is the field a downstream reader consults to answer what was done to the data and by whom. A record naming the wrong act does not merely lose precision; it documents an act that did not occur. That is the failure mode the standard exists to prevent, and it is the same root cause addressed at the generator level in MD-0006: a field populated on the strength of an act other than the one it denotes.

The alternative of leaving the candidate list intact and correcting only the worked examples was set aside. The list is where the adopter looks first, and correcting the derivative without the source leaves the defect reproducible.

Application

This decision governs the following corrections, which ship as one erratum release alongside MD-0006:

Artifact	Location	Correction
SPEC.md	line 473, §8.2	Remove dcm2niix from the <code>DeIdentification.Tool</code> candidate list. State that the field names the tool of the de-identification act only.
EXAMPLES.md	line 115	Correct Tool: dcm2niix under <code>DeIdentification</code> .
QUICKSTART.md	line 154	Same correction.

Change taxonomy: defect-fix. Per the registered taxonomy, the counterfactual test applies: the specification listed a format converter as a de-identification tool, which was false before this decision existed and would remain false without it. This decision records the semantics and authorizes the correction; it does not create the error, so governance-directed does not apply.

Do not touch. `ConversionTool`: `dcm2niix` at `SPEC.md:450`, `QUICKSTART.md:143`, `EXAMPLES.md:95`, `tools/vids_init.py:221` and six instances in `tests/generate_test_fixtures.py`. These are conversion records and are correct as written. Narrowing `DeIdentification.Tool` is what makes `ConversionTool` the right field for a converter, so a blanket search-and-remove of `dcm2niix` would break the corrected model.

The generator needs no change under this decision: `tools/vids_init.py` already writes `Tool: "TODO"`. Its `DeIdentification.Date: today` defect is governed by MD-0006 clause 2 and is corrected there.

Conformance impact is nil. Verified 2026-07-27 against the shipped artifact `vids_validator/validator.py` from `vids_validator-1.2.1-py3-none-any.whl` (PyPI, MD5 32462465a70eaf8c0025e40b8ec6c400, reporting `ValidatorVersion: 1.2.1`) and against `VALIDATION_RULES.md` on repository main. Neither contains any reference to `DeIdentification` or any of its subfields. The string at `SPEC.md:473` is a pipe-separated placeholder inside an illustrative example block, not a schema enumeration, and §8.2 requires only `VIDSVersion` within the sidecar, with all other fields `RECOMMENDED`. No dataset's validation outcome changes. The correction is an erratum, not a rule change, and the pull request must record that finding.

Scope

This decision fixes the meaning of one field. It does not:

- Change any dataset-conformance requirement or validation rule. Only `SPEC` does that, and only through the ratification path in `CONTRIBUTING.md`.
- Change the requirement level of any `DeIdentification` subfield. They remain `RECOMMENDED`.
- Touch `ConversionTool` or the conversion-record model.
- Enumerate an approved list of de-identification tools. Removing an incorrect entry is not an endorsement of the remainder.
- Determine which de-identification method Princeton Medical Systems applies or documents in any commercial engagement. That is a separate operational decision outside the standard.
- Cover assertion vocabulary or generator provenance population. That is MD-0006.

Consultation & decision record

Item	Record
Review window	Opened 2026-07-27 on proposal; closed 2026-07-30, when the Signature Copy was circulated for execution
Advisory Council opinion	None requested
Method	Consensus; approved by all three seated members without dissent
Vote count (if voted)	Not put to a vote. Unanimous approval of 3 of 3 seated members.
Recusals	None
Dissents	None

Sign-off

Maintainer	Decision	Approval date
Dr. Joan S. Muthu	Approved	2026-07-31
John Shalen R.	Approved	2026-07-31
John Xavier	Approved	2026-07-31

Approval evidence: MD-0007-ApprovalEvidence-2026-07-31.pdf

Signatories are the Steering Committee recorded under MD-0005 clause 2, each holding governance signatory authority under clause 3. MD-0005 was executed 2026-07-28, so that composition was in effect when this decision was signed. Acceptance took effect on the latest date of signature; the execution platform recorded completion of all three signatures at 10:22:55 UTC on 2026-07-31. This rendering contains no signature lines; signatures are held in the approval evidence cited above.

Change log

Date	Change
2026-07-27	Initial draft (Proposed).
2026-07-29	Revised during review: implementation scope, change taxonomy and verification records updated as recorded in the Application section.
2026-07-30	Signature Copy circulated for execution.
2026-07-31	Accepted following approval by Dr. Joan S. Muthu, John Shalen R., and John Xavier.

MD-0007 is a governance decision. It is non-normative with respect to dataset conformance: it changes no VIDS requirement and no validation rule.